

ple interact with about.gitlab.com. These tools are used most heavily by our Search Marketing team:

- Google Search Console (click data from Google Search)
- SEMRush (keyword research and coverage)
- Sitebulb (site health and crawl)

Google Marketing Platform

Google Marketing Platform is a central hub Google created to simplify managing their marketing suite. You can add/remove users and access each tool from their dashboards. It gives you admin control for

- Google Ads (not currently connected)
- Google Analytics
- Google Tag Manager
- Google Optimize
- Google dataStudio (not currently managed in Google Marketing Platform)
- Google Surveys (not currently in our marketing stack)

Google Marketing Platform is also where we manage data processing agreements and amendments for our GA 360 account.

Google Analytics flows

We use events to create flows to understand how people interact with about.gitlab.com. The simplest flows are built-in to Google Analytics. They answer questions like

- What page did someone visit? (Page dimension)
- How did they find that URL? (Source/Medium)
- How long were they on that page? (Average time on page)
- Did they enter and exit the site without visiting other pages? (% Exit)
- Did they leave the site from this page? (Bounce rate)

To create a deeper understanding we also employ custom events.

In the Event Category navigation you'll find events sorted by location in action and page with their label. This helps us identify what nav elements our visitors find most useful. A sample of our the most popular nav event you'll find in the Behavior > Events > Top Events section of GA is people clicking on sign in. Those events have the following values.

- Event category = navigation
- Event Action = main navigation header
- Event Label = <https://gitlab.com/users/signin>

To understand what offers people find compelling we use CTA events to see when people click on buttons to follow through from a page. We're looking to see what resources, webcasts, trial, or other offers lead people to take action. A sample of a popular CTA event would match these values in Behavior > Events > Top Events in Google Analytics.

Event category = CTA
Event action = button
Event label = <https://about.gitlab.com/>

To add further context, because lots of people visit our homepage, we can add a secondary dimension of Click URL or Click text to see what people clicked on. Try GitLab for FREE is the most popular click text, right from the CTA in our hero.

Finally, to help us measure conversion we use events as well. Every form on about.gitlab.com falls into one of several buckets, from resources to webcasts to trials. Trials are a little special right now because we don't have insight to SaaS trial activity, so we measure the last click we can see from </free-trial/> with the `saas-trial-clicks` label. A popular conversion event has the following values.

Event category = forms
Event action = submit
Event label = resources

You can add a secondary dimension to the label here as well to get additional context around which pages drive the most resource conversions. Add Page and you'll see which URL drove form conversions.

We also use these events to fire goal conversions in Google Analytics. Goals are not always available for analysis in every GA report, so we use as a reporting mechanism for our paid demand gen activities with PMG. We can assemble detailed reports on pageviews, CTA clicks, and form conversions in dataStudio.

Grouping pages together by sub-folder

A great way to look at how specific groups of pages are performing is available in the Content Drilldown view in Google Analytics. You start at the sub-domain level and can explore sub-folders to see which topic groups are performing well and to identify other trends.

GitLab Google Tag Manager system

We use Google Tag Manager(GTM) to simplify activity tracking on about.gitlab.com with Google Analytics. This documents the system the Digital Marketing Programs team uses with our Google Tag Manager container.

Data Attributes

Previously, GitLab use to track GTM through the use of various CSS classes. This has been an issue, as it obfuscates what is being tracked and why. To add some clarity, we highly recommend GitLab team members to start using data attributes.

Naming convention

We use semantic names for tags, triggers, and variables to make it simpler to determine what these components are supposed to do. Use an em dash (shift+option-) to divide the components of each GTM component name.

Tags start with the platform, followed by the tag's purpose, and are finally contextualized to about.gitlab.com. Any tags related to timed events need the timeframe indicated in a note attached to the tag in GTM to make it clear when to remove a tag.

Tag naming examples

Google Analytics Event · Free Trial CTA click
Google Ads · conversion tracker
Facebook · base pixel
Drift · snippet v 0.3.1

Triggers start with a description of the action triggering a tag, followed by contextualization for about.gitlab.com.

Trigger naming examples

Link click · Learn more 100M carousel
CTA click · cta-btn
Custom event · mktoformSubmit free trial

Variables start with the tag or trigger they reference, followed by contextual data about their purpose.

Variable naming examples

Google Analytics · GitLab Universal Analytics ID
dataLayer · postType custom dimension

If you are making changes to the GTM container and have questions about what to name one of these components the Digital Marketing Programs team can help.

dataLayer values

Today we're using the dataLayer sparingly on about.gitlab.com, with our primary use focused on differentiating blog content with postType. We'll expand how we use the dataLayer to create content groupings for improved customer journey insights and document those updates here.

Event tags

We need consistent tags across Google Analytics events and have introduced the following structure to our event tags. Our goal is to cover important visitor events with the smallest number of tags in Google Tag Manager. Reducing the number of tags and the overall complexity of our Google Tag Manager container helps us spot and fix coverage issues faster.

Event structure

Some tools fire events with out of the box nomenclature that we can't alter. Drift and Demandbase populate default Event Categories you can explore to discover Event Action and Event Labels.

GitLab controlled Event Categories include navigation, CTA, forms, and YouTube events. Details for each of these categories can also be extended with Custom Dimensions in Google Analytics. Our current custom dimensions include Click URL, Click text, Click class, and referrer. Referrer shows you the previous page for any event, whether it's an internal page or external resource.

Navigation events capture how visitors interact with navigation across about.gitlab.com. If you select the navigation category you can explore different parts of our global navigation and more specific interactions like clicks from docs to about.

Event Category	Event Action	Event Label
navigation	main navigation header	Click URL
	footer link category	
	docs to about	
	search interactions	
	click	

CTA events capture how visitors interact with call to action buttons across about.gitlab.com. We use cta-btn for each CTA button across about.gitlab.com to trigger these events. Select CTA to explore these events.

Event Category	Event Action	Event Label
CTA	button	Page
	video	
	inline link	
	click	
	watch	
	select plan	
	challenge box	

Forms capture when visitors submit a form on about.gitlab.com. The key factor to check here is the Event Label where you can see the total number of events by offer type for your selected time frame.

Event Category	Event Action	Event Label
forms	submit	saas-trial-click
		resources
		webcasts
		trial
		demo
		mktoLead
		PathFactory
		sales
		services
		events

The YouTube Event Category is a newer event type on about.gitlab.com. As we use ramp up using

YouTube to embed videos across our website we wanted to see which videos resonate with visitors and how much of a video visitors watch.

Event Category	Event Action	Event Label
-----	-----	-----
YouTube	Start playing	Video title + video URL
	Reached 50%	
	Reached the end	

Event structure January 2019 - June 2020

Starting in January 2019 we used an updated event structure designed to maximize our understanding of interactions across about.gitlab.com with the limitations of Google Analytics. We transitioned off of this system early in June 2020, so if you look at events before then you might encounter this event structure.

These three components help us organize and identify specific event data. Event Categories help us group specific customer journey steps, Event Actions describe visitor interactions with about.gitlab.com, and Event Labels provide contextual details for reporting our performance.

Example Event Label

{{Page URL}} | {{Referrer}} | {{Click text}} | {{Click URL}} | {{Click Class}}

Google Analytics limits event label fields to around 2000 characters, and we'll update the handbook if we start to see truncated event labels.

Google Tag Manager inventory

We're using Simo Ahava's Google Sheets Add-On to sync notes for our tags and create a GitLab Google Tag Manager inventory This simplifies scanning and searching over the Google Tag Manager web app.

Changes of note

Whenever we make major changes to tags through Google Tag Manager we document them in changes of note. Examples of changes we document are adding or removing tags, changing tag sequencing, or changing when a tag is fired.

Using marketing trend data

Search term volume is hard to estimate. Different tools use different methodologies and models for reporting this data. AdWords provides data from Google, but the ranges are broad and terms can be combined into a single phrase. Google Trend data normalizes search trends from 1 to 100 based on the terms you're exploring, which doesn't give us any idea of how many people are using a particular phrase.

For our keyword research we rely on Moz Keyword Explorer data because it provides a narrower volume with full phrase integrity. When we report keyword volume, this is the tool we use for

this data.

Google Analytics Crash Course

Dimensions vs Metrics

Dimensions are the different attributes of your data. For example, the landing page is a dimension that is the first page a person views when they come to the site.

Metrics are the numbers that are being measured, such as number of page views or number of sessions.

Each dimension and metric has a scope, so it's important to understand the three different scopes:

- 1. User-level
- 1. Session-level
- 1. Page-level

Due to the scoping, not every dimension can be combined with every metric. In most cases, the dimensions and the metrics should match the scope.

Understanding Reporting

Setting a date range

You can use the calendar in the top right to set the active date range. You can also select the compare to box to compare metrics from different time periods. This will allow you to see month over month or year over year growth for the desired metrics.

Annotations

Annotations are used to mark a point in time in Google Analytics. They can be used to mark an important event such as a change to the setup of Google Analytics, or an event that heavily impacted traffic positively or negatively.

To create an annotation, double-click on a date. The double-click will bring up the annotation field where you can enter details, and select private or public. Public annotations can be seen by anyone that has access to that view within Google Analytics, and private annotations can only be seen by you.

Data Tables

Most reports have a data table below the graph. The data tables contain a dimension and associated metrics.

The Primary Dimension of the data tables can be changed by selecting a different primary dimension from above the table.

A secondary dimension can also be added by clicking on the Secondary Dimension button above the

table and selecting the secondary dimension you'd like to add to the table.

Audience Reports

The audience reports are used to understand characteristics of your users such as location, and browser used, and user behavior over multiple visits such as average session time.

Acquisition Reports

The acquisition reports help you know how people find the website. These reports will help you to analyze the benefits of the different digital marketing efforts that you are involved in.

Channels Report

The All Traffic > Channels report breaks down all the different channels that are sending traffic to the site. You can click on any of the channels to drill down and get more granular data about that specific channel. For example, if you click on the Referral channel, you will see which sites are referring traffic to your site.

Behaviors Reports

The behaviors section is about how users use the website. This includes what pages of the site people are looking at as well as how they flow through the site.

All Pages Report

The All Pages report shows the number of times a given page was viewed within the selected period of time. You can change the primary dimension to Page Title if it is easier to tell what the page is by looking at the title rather than the URL.

Avg. Time on Page and Bounce Rate can be used to find underperforming content or content that is very engaging to users and can be used in future marketing efforts.

Landing Pages and Exit Pages

The Landing Pages and Exit Pages reports are scoped at the session and tell us how many people are beginning a session at a certain page (landing page) and how many people are ending a session at a certain page (exit page).

These reports can be valuable to see what content is bringing people to the site and what content is causing people to leave the site.

Events

Events can be set up to track actions that people take on the website, such as clicking links or selecting drop downs. These events can be set up in Google Tag Manager and for the most part won't require any additional code to be placed on the website.

SECTION: marketing/inbound-marketing/search-marketing/handbook-error-mash.md

The Search Marketing team wants to ask for your help to fix SEO errors across the handbook. For the next 4 weeks, we're asking teams to look at their section of the handbook and fix duplicate or missing page titles, descriptions, and broken links.

To help you get started the Search Marketing team recorded a few videos to show how to fix these types of errors and collected errors in a Google Sheet.

As you fix errors, please add the ~site-health label so we can track how many MRs we complete in this iteration and help us improve as we do future iterations.

Website Health errors Google Sheet

The Website Health sheet has five tabs, Missing Meta Descriptions, Duplicate Titles, Duplicate Meta Descriptions, Broken Internal Links and Broken External Links.

The title and description tabs both have the page with an error, team, and a checkbox to mark an error as fixed.

The broken link tab lists the link location (where a broken link occurs), the broken link, and the link text. There's also a team listed, and checkbox for completion.

Videos

The Search Marketing team made a series of videos showing why fixing these errors will help GitLab's SEO and how to fix each type of issue in the WebIDE. You can find all of these in the Improving Website Health playlist on GitLab Unfiltered.

Handbook error mash kickoff video

```
<figure class="videocontainer">
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/QHBuAwX3pDs" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>
```

Fixing page titles and meta descriptions

```
<figure class="videocontainer">
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/SOOUYUirWZik" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>
```

```
<figure class="videocontainer">
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/hcw63x5TGGk" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>
```

Broken links and 301 redirects


```
<figure class="videocontainer">
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/W40ciCKtzpk" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>
```

While you're fixing those broken links, consider making the link text meaningful if it isn't already. This helps to improve our site's accessibility for people who use screen readers.

```
<figure class="videocontainer">
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/1K8irzpGExY" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>
```

```
<figure class="videocontainer">
  <iframe src="https://www.youtube.com/embed/VE1gpOzyufs" frameborder="0"
allowfullscreen="true"> </iframe>
</figure>
```

SECTION: marketing/inbound-marketing/search-marketing/seo-content-manual.md

Introduction and Purpose

The aim of this manual is to help create content that provides use and value to both searchers and search engines.

SEO optimising content during the initial production phase ensures maximum impact from launch in terms of attracting qualified traffic and delivering to them valid content that matches the searchers query in terms of both topic and intent.

Goal

Ideally, marrying both content writing skills with SEO helps to meet the E.A.T (Expertise, Authority, Trust) requirements of search engines such as Google. To do so two elements are required:

1. The content created has to be relevant, informative and engaging
2. The search engine needs to be able to discern what the content is about, what information it provides to the user, and most importantly, whether it provides better information than those you are topically competing with.

The goal of this unification is to:

1. Rank as high as possible in SEARCH results for specific topics and related terms. To drive qualified traffic - not just general traffic
2. To engage and create brand trust and return visits
3. To convince readers to take specific actions and to convert
4. To create an optimized internal linking structure which indicates relevance, relationships between content pieces as well as funnels for pushing traffic through general buyer journey

stages

Ideally, content production takes a topic first approach. Meaning, target topics are identified which is followed by keyword research which maps keywords to the identified topics.

Digital Content Publication SEO Checklist

Creating valuable content means not just publicizing useful and attractive information, but also assuring that the information can be found. The following is a checklist which goes through each step required to make sure that all content is fully optimized before digital publication.

Quick summary of on page elements that require inclusion

1. Include your keyword in the URL
2. Keep URLs as short as possible
3. Front load your keyword in your Title Tag
4. Embed Title Tag modifiers
5. Use your keyword (or variants) in the subheadings (H1,H2,H3)
6. Use your keyword as close to the beginning of the first paragraph of text as possible.
7. Optimize your images (image Alt Tags)
8. Use semantic keyword terms within the copy
9. Use external links to authoritative sites, but ensure any external links open in a new window so as not to end the session - try to ensure that any external links are placed low down in the copy, after any prioritised or strategic links.
10. Use internal links and use keyword rich anchor text which indicates the pages relationship. Also target pages which funnel traffic through buyer stages.
11. Avoid long sentences, as this also puts readers off. If a sentence goes over two and a half sentences in length, then it should most likely be broken into two separate sentences. Keep direct and to the point.
12. Strategically place CTAs within the page, not just header and footer.

Double check the following prior to publication

Findable content: does the content include?

- Primary keyword target in URL
- A H1 tag (with keyword target)
- At least 2 H2 tags (with keyword target or keyword variants)
- Placement of the target keyword as close to the beginning of the first sentence on the first paragraph as possible.
- Metadata that matches the intent of the page content, including title tag, meta description and keywords properly placed
- Inclusion of semantic terms where possible
- Links to other related content (internal/external)
- Alt tags for images (with related keyword/variants)

Readable content: does the content include?

- An inverted pyramid writing style

- Chunking
- Bullet points where necessary
- Numbered lists where necessary
- Follow a style guide for consistency in terminology etc

Understandable content: does the content include?

- An appropriate content type (text, video, etc).
- Reflection that you used the buyer persona
- Context
- Respect for the audiences reading level
- Present an old idea in a new way

Actionable content; does the content include?

- A call to action (strategically placed and matching the searchers intent)
- A specific solution to a pain point (preferably identified using buyer persona data)
- A place to comment
- An invitation to share
- Links to related content
- A direct summary of what to do

Identifying customer language to use in keyword targeting

When identifying what key terms to target within the keyword research process it is important to ensure the use of valid and current customer terminology for a specific target topic.

Over time, the way topics or categories are discussed by professionals or industry users can alter, expand, contract and evolve. As such, it is essential to remain current with the customers' language.

At GitLab we have access to valuable resources that help inform, validate and evolve the targeting process.

A brief overview of some of the most valuable resources and assets that are utilized as part of the cyclical keyword planning stage.

1. Product and Solution Marketing - linking with a member of the team and accessing their wealth of information and research resources provides exceptional insight into our customers allowing for up to date targeting using customer focus language and needs.

1. Key personas & pain points - user persona research assists in the identification of possible keyword targets for a specific audience based on their requirements, motivations and pain points. As a resource, this is excellent for establishing problem solving keyword targets for specific segments.

1. Chorus - provides information and insight based on customer conversations, and most importantly, using their own language. The filtering and analysis of discussion transcripts inform keyword targeting research and assist in the identification of current terms. An additional benefit is the capability of contextual analysis of specific terms.

Using data and research to understand the evolving needs of the customer as well as their preferences for terminology allow for the development of targeted strategies that maximise impact.

The incorporation of this information into the planning stage ensures a focus on user intent as well as the delivery of highly relevant solution based content.

Content planning and research tools

All content projects begin with solid research that aligns keyword targeting research with topical analysis. To create a content plan, you need a clear idea of your goals and the message you are trying to convey through your content.

Various tools allow for the analysis of search engine results to identify what the algorithms are delivering in top search positions for a target term.

Using this information, in alignment with keyword research, it is possible to plan content production, as well as on page information structure, based on data.

Once gathered and analysed, the information can be used to inform new content production, as well as for updating/optimising older content assets through gap analysis.

The following tools are excellent resources for the content planning stage and provide a wealth of actionable information:

Thruuu

Provides a breakdown of the top results per searched term as well as on page structure (H1,H2, H3), metadata and an audit of all on page links.

AlsoAsked

Provides an organised view of which questions searchers are asking about a specific topic, and also the hierarchy of how those questions are linked together.

Answer The Public

This tool looks at autocomplete data from search engines and quickly provides large listings of phrases and questions that people are asking related to your target keyword or topic.

Answer Socrates

Socrates uses a combination of various Google suggest sites, as well as People Also Asked questions, with search trends data.

All resources above allow for data exporting, meaning an extensive data research file can be compiled on any topic you wish to target. These resources can simplify the content planning stage through data based decision making.

Explanation of general terms

Keyword list

Keyword lists are provided during the research stage based on targeting parameters and requirements. Each list is researched and scored to identify targeting opportunities based on multiple criteria such as search volume, competitiveness etc. The keywords are then tagged based on any intent modifiers in order to segment targeting by intent stage and to maximise impact.

When a keyword list has been used for a project stage, it is important to highlight any terms used as the primary page target within the document. This helps to ensure no retargeting of the same term takes place and avoid any keyword cannibalization issues down the line.

Keyword lists are updated frequently, and identifying already targeted terms helps improve the process and also to initiate keyword tracking within campaign structures when required.

Keyword grouping

This is where overlapping keywords are identified within a keyword list and grouped to target on a singular page to maximise organic traffic for a topic.

This helps ensure that multiple pages are not produced for a series of keywords which can then end up competing for each other for traffic.

Resource: <https://moz.com/learn/seo/multiple-keywords-video>

Semantic keywords

Semantic keywords should also be applied to a page where possible, these are terms that google likes to see present based on the target topic and highlights how extensively a topic is covered based on content which currently ranks in SEARCH.

Lists of semantic terms are provided to the content writer during the research phase along with keyword lists and trending topic analysis.

Resource: <https://backlinko.com/hub/seo/lsi>

Natural language

It is important to always place natural language at the forefront of page optimization. Key terms are used when appropriate and should never be placed in circumstances where they do not sound natural (keyword stuffing).

Trending topics and related questions

During the research phase, keyword lists are provided to content writers along with trending topic lists and lists of trending questions.

- Trending topics allow for the writers to research the top 10 ranking articles for their target topic.
- Trending questions are identified questions that pop up most frequently, and can be used

within articles (use exact wording) and to provide comprehensive sought after answers.

Searcher intent

Each webpage and the content that is placed on it should be focused on user intent. Your content will vary depending on what stage of a customer journey your reader is at. And so should your keywords.

- Informational Intent
- Commercial Intent
- Navigational Intent
- Transactional Intent

When targeting a specific keyword term, the SEO team will provide a data set of keywords which fall under this overall target. The keyword list will be categorized so as that the list can be filtered into the three primary targets of intent.

This will allow for the mapping of individual articles which can be produced to tackle a customer at each buyer stage.

See more on this topic covered below.

Gap analysis

This process has two elements, internal and external.

- Internal: what content do we have internally that already covers this topic - this ensures we do not create keyword cannibalization issues as well as help to optimize a content clustering strategy approach in terms of linking.

- External: What content do our competitors have that cover this topic, what is performing well for this in search, what format does it take? We use this information to inform our own production.

Pyramid style writing technique

As readers tend to drop off according to the 80/20 rule (80% drop off after the initial 20% of page content) it can be good practice to top load the page copy with content that includes a solution to the searchers pain point. Addressing the issue here, and then moving into broader areas of the topic following this helps to ensure that the solution is provided while attention is still maintained.

Content should be formatted for scan ability; most site visitors have a very limited attention span and therefore it is best to use an inverted pyramid style. This refers to cramming all the important points into the beginning of an article or piece and then broadening as it moves on. This way the most beneficial marketing points have a higher chance of impact within this limited time frame even if the recipient bounces.

It can also be good practice to include a CTA following this to help promote action related to the searchers pain point, and the solution which is being provided.

Resource: <https://yoast.com/inverted-pyramid/>

Sentence length

Sentences within articles will vary in length. Accumulated short sentences make a text seem choppy and hard to digest, overly long sentences can seem overly complicated and dull to a reader. Therefore, a healthy mixture of both is favorable. However, shorter, clearer and more impactful sentences are preferable. (Short sentences < 17 words / long sentences > 35 words)

Any sentence which is more than 2-3 sentences long on a word document can generally be broken into two separate sentences. The 2.5-3 lines long category is generally above and beyond the recommended limit except in exceptional circumstances.

Use active text instead of passive text

Avoid the use of passive text. Overuse of passive text is seen as non-persuasive and also as poor writing. It allows the object of an action to be the subject of the sentence. On average this should be kept below 20% of the overall text, generally depending on the type of piece that is to be generated.

With the active voice, you learn 'who' or 'what' is responsible for the action at the beginning of the sentence. In other words, when the subject acts, the verb is active.

Active voice tends to make text shorter, clearer and more impactful - most importantly, active text is more persuasive:

- Passive voice example: Groceries were bought by my parents for my sister's birthday party.
- Active voice example: My parents bought groceries for my sister's birthday party.

On-page factors to consider

Page URL

This is one of the primary elements crawled by search engines to understand the context of a page. Be sure to include your core target term within the URL structure. This is essential to include during initial creation. Altering URLs at a later date is not advisable unless essential for other purposes.

Title tag

Your meta title tag should be accurate and descriptive. It shows as the heading above your meta description on the search results page and as such strongly impacts the click through rate. The text should, in general, be no longer than 60-70 characters (though this is finally determined by pixel length) and should contain key terms related to the page.

Going over this threshold increases the chance your title will be truncated in search results. Google will automatically rewrite title tag text on average of 30% of the time. Keeping it under the recommended threshold helps to mitigate this, but is no guarantee. However, even when Google does rewrite meta data, it still utilises the original information to assist in

distinguishing the purpose/target of the page - so original input data is still important.

The text between your title tags is often displayed on search engine results pages (SERPs). These tags are therefore useful in both SEO and for social sharing.

Meta Description tag

Meta descriptions do not have a direct impact on SEO, however, they are heavily influential on organic CTR from SERPs. As such, is considered a key SEO element. Be sure to include the core term, and provide a strong CTA description that promotes the value of the content in relation to the intent of the search query.

Your meta description tag is a unique, and clear description of what is featured on the page and appears below a page link/title on SERPs. A good meta description can increase your click-through rate.

- 140-160 characters long
- Include your keyword
- Add a call-to-action
- Avoid duplication
- Make them meaningful

Once again, search engines (Google) regularly alter metadata (avg 30%) and as a rule, you should not exceed a meta description length of 70-160 characters to help minimise this, also anything over this threshold will be truncated and the power of the messaging or CTA will be lost.

Heading tags (H1, H2)

Headers are the things which summarise the pages you create for both consumers and search engines, as well as being important stylistically.

All content, barring news articles, should consist of a H1 and subsequent H2 breaking up each section. This is for SEO and reader scan ability.

Keywords should be used in H1 and also as close as possible to the beginning of the first sentence of paragraph 1. This is as the Google bots scan pages from the top down when deciding how relative they are.

H1 tags

`<h1></h1>` This tag is your main page heading · it's from this that Google will take one of its first impressions of your page's relevance to a search query. It is important for page relevance that these contain the information you wish to rank for, such as your target keywords. Though there is no definitive limit, best practice dictates that you should attempt to keep your titles unique, between 60 and 80 characters, and with keywords near the beginning.

H1s are major ranking indicators, a page should only contain a single H1 (in certain cases your title will be your H1, depending on page template format).

H2 & H3 tags

As mentioned above, keywords and their placement within H1 headers can be strong influential factors, particularly for the core term target. In other elements such as H2s and H3s, you can also use the core term, or variances of it as well as semantically related topical terms.

`<h2></h2>` are also good for use as stand-alone subheadings for breaking up content and allowing for ease and speed of understanding. Readers will at times scan the content for relative sections, such headers quickly identify content they may require.

`<h3></h3>` This is your sub-sub and its formatting should denote its place as a paragraph leader, or stand-out line. Only use a H3 if necessary and siving into a subcatagory topic.

This system of heading substructures helps identify the breadth of the topic covered as well as the informational hierarchy of the page content to both users and search engines.

Image Alt tag

When utilizing images, use the target keyword in the filename of the image, the image title, and the ALT tag. Doing so optimizes the file for image searches.

Secondly, optimized image file sizes are extremely important and directly affect page load times which are a key SEO factor. Images should be compressed to suit page requirements.

Your image tag also provides an explanation of images to search engines, which can be used in conjunction with various modifiers to position it according to your needs. This is another factor of on-page optimization.

Text link (hyperlink)

Used for your on page links (your hypertext underlines), the anchor text should give easily inferred signals about what awaits them on the destination page. This is good for both the searcher and search engines, as it indicates to the search engine the relationship between the current page and the one that the link is connected to.

On-page linking (internal and external)

Linking strategies, both internal and external are key parts of both the SEO strategy as well as the internal user flow funneling strategy (moving users through funnel stages).

Internal linking

Whenever publishing a new piece of content, it is important to include links to 2-5 other pages within your site. This process is ideal for identifying relationships between content groups/clusters or for mapping a buyer journey so as to funnel traffic to the next stage of conversion. It is also important than when launching a new page you link out to that page from a pre-existing, and topically related page. Doing so can help speed up both the ranking and indexing process for the new page.

Be sure to use keyword rich anchor text for your internal links as these help indicate context

to both the searcher and search engines.

Internal links have multiple purposes for SEO. They signal to search engines how much you cover a topic not just through the initial page, but also linked pages and this helps boost topical expertise. Providing links to related pages can also increase page views and engagement and build brand trust and push users towards conversion.

More internal links also keep search bots on the site longer and assist in indexing more of the website's content.

Internal link structure also allows for the strategic passing of page equity within the site and can boost page authority and help increase positioning.

A page's equity is passed through the links the page contains, and is in a sense divided between the number of links on the given page. The position of the links can also influence the amount of importance that a search engine will allocate to it.

To search engines, the most valuable links on a page are those within the content, most credence is given to the first links encountered within the page copy. Use these links as your primary strategic links for both funneling users to next stage content and also for link equity passing.

If you have multiple links on a page to the same page, the first of the links will be given credence by search engines. A header and footer links pass less equity than internal content links, if a link exists in the page header and also in the page content, credence will be given to the header link and the value of the internal content link will be devalued.

External linking

External links to trusted websites are an important means of showing search engines that your content is well-referenced, trustworthy and backed up. However, be careful where you place these links, too close to the top of the page and you could be funneling traffic away from the site.

Also, be careful not to link to content that is covering the very same topic, as searchers may travel to the external page and be drawn into their buyer funnel as it provides information on the same query/intent.

External links should be low within the page copy, internal links take precedence and this will minimize user drop off.

Anchor text

Anchor text is the text used for the hyperlink when adding a link within the page copy, this text is extremely important as it gives search engines a description of the context of the link and the relationship between the two pages.

Ensure you use descriptive text that is succinct and relevant to the page you are linking to, and not text such as "click here" etc., which provides no context or value.

Anchor text 5 basic types

1. Exact match: exact match to the target term of the page (eg. "GitOps" linking to GitOps page).
2. Partial match: anchor text that includes a variation of the core target term of the linked page (eg. "benefits of GitOps" to GitOps page)
3. Branded: using "GitLab" as anchor text
4. Generic: avoid these, as they provide no value ("click here" or "read more" as anchor text)
5. Naked anchor text: also avoid as they provide no context (this would consist of a URL link: www.xyz.com/topcs/devops/)

Image anchors are another form of link anchor (non-text). When using images as an anchor for a link, search engines will utilize the image's alt attribute as the anchor text (goes back to why images need to be optimized).

Optimisation strategies

Simple steps for creating ranking content

1. Choose your target keyword
2. Analyze the SERP results and analyze the competition
3. Create or optimize a page that aligns with searcher intent (as outlined above)
4. Cover topic in full and provide value
5. Build backlinks (more than the competition) and add internal links
6. Be prepared to wait - ranking takes time

SEO is a long-term game. Many strategies require more than six months to show results. Some strategies can provide faster impact/results, but overall strategies are rolled out in cadences and are long-term. Patience is a key to success when vying for competitive top positions.

It is important to remember that there are multiple mitigating factors that need to be allowed for, these include:

- Competitor strategies
- Competitiveness of query terms and aligning intent
- Search engine algorithm updates
- Seasonality
- Internal issues/changes
- ...and more!

Satisfying searcher intent - an extremely important strategic factor

SEO is not optimizing for machines. It is optimizing for users and implementing specific elements to ensure that our content is crawled, indexed, and seen as best in class in order to be allotted a top result for a given topical query.

It is aligning with the AI and ML system processes that search engines have developed in order to provide users with the exact, and best, content that satisfies the user's search query intent.

If search engines did not give users the best results for their query, Google would not be what it is today. The whole premise of the search engine is to solve a searcher's problem, completely, efficiently, and effectively. This process is continually evolving and improving.

Searcher intent explained

There are four primary levels of searcher intent, and understanding these allows us to segment target keywords into these groups. Doing so helps us understand the format and type of content that we need to produce in order to consolidate a page one position in SERPs for a particular query.

The main types of search intent are:

- Informational: (know) the searcher is looking for information, a content-heavy resource that provides valuable insight into a specified topic - generally top of the funnel, blogs, topics page, etc.
- Commercial investigation: (prove) the searcher is within the mid-funnel stage for this type of search intent, is seeking research and data to inform a decision prior to purchasing. This data may be for themselves, or for a senior member of the team who is the decision-maker.
- Transactional: (do) at this stage the user is actively wanting to purchase and terms will include modifiers related to purchasing/cost etc.
- Navigational: (go) users with this intent are trying to find a specific website or web page (most often branded searches).

A simple and easy way to deconstruct the searcher intent behind a query is to type it into a search engine. Look at the first page of results for the query, examine the format of the content of those results.

What format does the resulting content take, a blog, a topics page, or a solutions page? Are the titles predominantly include terms such as "how, what, where, methods, etc" this would all indicate informational intent.

If the intent is informational, provide as much relevant content as is possible and help educate the user on the query topic. Thoroughly cover the topic, and answer common questions.

Terms such as "best, top, etc" would indicate commercial intent. To align with this type of search query intent, provide the searcher with the information required to make a particular decision (reviews, pricing, comparisons, FAQs, etc.)

If the intent is transactional, optimize the copy for this and emphasize specific conversion value points within the page title and copy. Keep the content focused on the desired outcome (eg. buying a product). This page type will not require loads of supporting content, unlike an informational intent page.

Creating content that aligns with, and satisfies, searcher intent

The easiest way to deconstruct a strategy from the SERP results is utilizing the four Cs

concept:

1. Content-type
2. Content format
3. Content angle
4. Content coverage

Content-type: this refers to the most common "type" of content that is in the top search results and can consist of blog posts, a product page, a category page, or a landing page. Examining the titles and URLs can inform the proper content format to match searcher intent.

Content format: examine the competition and identify what format the top results take - are the how-to guides, reviews, comparisons, or other such formats.

Content angle: at this point aim to distinguish the universal selling point (USP) of the top results, who are they targeted at, and how?

Content coverage: it is important to cover the topic in-depth, identify the topics/subtopics covered by the competitors and include these, also fill any gaps that they may have, and most importantly provide additional useful information that they lack.

New page creation and existing on-page optimizations

The following optimizations work for top of funnel (ToF) content (both blogs or topics-related content, independent of the off-page informational hierarchy structure).

Identify the target topic for the page, from this research and focus on a primary keyword.

- Note that short tail keywords tend to have higher search volume, but much higher competition and also lower intent value as they are broader in query.
- Long-tail keywords tend to have lower search volume but higher intent, and at times easier to rank for.

Once the core target term is identified, run competitor analysis and see what is ranking on page 1 of SERPs for that type of query. Take note of the content format, and also note what subtopics are covered on each page. This will help define the information types and value that users look for relating to the query and that search engines deliver to satisfy the search query intent.

Next, identify semantic terms related to the core target topic as well as variances of the original term. Create a list of these and utilize them within the copy when executing the content.

A final task, identifying People Also Asked (PAA) queries using Google. These are lists of queries semantically related to the core topic that users also searched for while searching for your target topic. Utilizing this information, you can be sure to provide a strong authoritative page on the topic.

Once this data is compiled, the next step is to create a page brief and build out the skeleton of the page to be created/or content sections to add or optimize (depending on if this is a new or existing page).

Compiling a content brief should include:

1. Page title
2. Meta description
3. Page URL
4. Intent stage
5. Primary keyword
6. Secondary keywords
7. Suggested header sections (H1s, H2s, H3s)
8. Main internal link target
9. Some competitor URLs for gap analysis

[Link to example brief for new blog page creation](#)

Historical Optimisations

Not only is historical blog optimization a way to get more out of the content you already have, it's also a way to get a leg up on such a competitive landscape by keeping your content evergreen and delivering even more value to the people reading it.

This tactic is so effective simply because the content has been indexed for much longer and already has some authority in Google, which in turn will make it easier for your optimized post to gain traction and start moving up the ranks.

Before you start updating random articles, though, you should take a strategic approach to get the biggest impact and identify critical articles to optimize.

How to identify which articles to optimize

When it comes to optimizing your past articles, the primary focus is on four core areas:

1. Low-converting articles
2. High bounce rate articles
3. Highly-indexed, low-clicked articles from the Search Engine Results Page (SERP)
4. Page one ranking opportunity articles

When not focusing on individual page optimisations, it is best to categorize and group pages based on the above and to optimize each group within a project setting.

Low-converting articles

You spend so much time, effort, and money creating quality blog articles. Ideally, you're getting a ton of traffic to your site because of it. Traffic is great, but we need people to contact you and get in your sales pipeline.

By focusing on low converting articles, you'll be able to make small updates that can help drive big results

High bounce rate articles

Having a higher bounce rate with your blog articles than your website pages is common because most people are looking to find specific educational information and, once they have read it, they tend to leave your site. But that does not mean you settle for high bounce rates from your articles! If these pages have good dwell time from the readers it means the content is delivering the required information and the reader is engaged. But we would look for a means of driving that traffic further into the funnel and reduce the bounce rate. If the time on page is low, then most likely the content did not align with the intent of the searcher and requires analysis.

High-indexed, low-clicked articles

Articles that receive a significant number of impressions in search engines but not a lot of clicks through to your site is a perfect optimization opportunity to dramatically increase your traffic. By making some minimal tweaks to page titles and meta descriptions, you can encourage more searchers to click through to your site.

Page one ranking opportunity articles

These are articles that are currently on pages two or three of Google's search results. You're close to seeing a big traffic increase if you can improve the content of those articles and get them on page one of the SERP. Moving to this position greatly increases the CTR %.

Individual Page Optimisations (Unique Tasks)

Individual page optimization projects (post-production) would differ in approach as each undertaking would require the analysis of the data of each individual page to be optimized.

As such, using the checklist document discussed would be beneficial for the inclusion of any missing elements, but would also include:

- Analysis of the page performance metrics to identify the underlying performance issues
- Analysis of the page structure to identify any UX issues
- Analysis of on-page SEO factors
- Gap analysis of competing content

Content clustering strategy

Process and application

A content clustering strategy uses internal linking structures and topic modelling to indicate to search engine crawlers the relationship between content pages. Using this approach helps to provide such crawlers with an overview of the site's topic ownership and expertise on certain subjects and as such boost search performance.

It is a means of organising and archiving content by subject matter and provides an intentional, organized and structured approach to SEO content production.

Primary elements

1. Pillar page - this page is a broad piece of content that covers your target topic, it also

acts as the primary hub for your cluster. Like a hub in the centre of an old cart wheel with multiple spokes providing support.

2. Cluster pages - these pages are internally linked, to and from, your topic pillar page. Each page provides an in-depth look at specific subtopics related to the primary topic target.

3. Internal links - the links act as the bridge that ties all the elements together, passes equity between pages to improve topic coverage and ranking.

4. Hierarchical URL structure - reinforces the value of the cluster, allows search engines to understand the semantic coverage of the topic and easily navigate the informational hierarchy, and increases topical authority.

The linking structure indicates to search engines what the relationship between all elements of the structure are, and also the level of expertise and knowledge that a site can provide on a given topic.

Google uses its Google RankBrain algorithm to evaluate pages for ranking and determine what results to provide for a given search query based on intent.

Utilizing this approach helps positively influence factors that this algorithm uses when evaluating both quality and authority of a site/topic.

A cluster strategy is a prime approach to gaining page one position rankings for competitive short-tail keywords that are informational in intent (ToF) and highly competitive within specific niches.

Executing a content clustering strategy

1. Identify goals and execute keyword research based on the target topic. Execute gap analysis on performing competitive content to identify what has traction within search based on intent type.

2. Execute internal content audit and identify existing live assets which can be included within the cluster. This has two main impacts, firstly it ensures we are not creating overlapping content and, secondly including live content that has traction speeds up the ranking process.

3. Establish a pillar page to tie these assets together and formalise your cluster and provide a hub for your links to and from these pages. At times it is possible to expand upon a suitable existing page to create your pillar page, other times it may be necessary to create a new page to satisfy this function.

4. Establish your internal linking structure to tie all elements together. All cluster pages should link to the pillar page, and the pillar page should link out to all the cluster pages. Be sure to use optimized anchor text terms for your hyperlinks.

Maintenance of your content cluster

Once established content clusters can be added to regularly, as well as tracking and optimising assets within the cluster. A common question is how many cluster pages should be in a content cluster?

Answer: as many as you can think of. The trick is to continually identify content gaps within your cluster by means of research and to fill these.

SECTION: marketing/inbound-marketing/search-marketing/seo-strategy.md

GitLab's go-to-market success depends on people organically discovering our product and company. The two primary ways we achieve organic discovery are with our brand and search engine optimization (SEO). Our SEO strategy will take advantage of our existing strengths and improve critical areas to ensure our ideal visitors find GitLab through search engines.

Our goal is to gather relevant visitors from organic search with authoritative pages and engage them with next step content.

Why SEO?

We live in a world where search is a natural motion. If you want to know when your favorite lunch spot opens, you Google it. When you're stuck on a problem at work, you look for the answer with Google. Trusted domains build brand authority over time and become a preferred destination for their target audience. Stack Overflow answers developer questions and GitHub for specific projects are two great examples of authoritative sites for developers.

It's our job to help GitLab become an authority on DevOps and the software development lifecycle.

Optimizing our site to answer questions about our product and market gives us a path to serendipitously meet the needs of our customers, prospects, and potential customers. We will tailor the content of pages to match the different stages of the buyer's journey.

Optimization segments

There are three optimization segments for search at GitLab.

As of November 2020, you can rank our performance in these areas in that order. Branded search is a strong driver of visitors to our public sub-domains, and unbranded search is improving to join branded search as a source of significant traffic.

1. Branded search
1. Unbranded search
1. Product search

Branded search is typically the second optimization segment to send significant traffic, but in GitLab's case this is where we gain the bulk of our traffic. GitLab CI or GitLab pricing are a couple of examples of branded search terms where we win traffic in 2020.

Challenges we face

about.gitlab.com is a user-generated content site managed by the GitLab team without the traditional controls UGC sites typically employ. We're working to address this by adding a CMS and other methods of control, and we'll need to continue to innovate to deliver search optimization as we scale.

Visitor strategy

Blog visitors don't convert at the same rate as product page visitors

We will help the blog attract visitors and help those visitors discover product pages.

The Search Marketing team will focus our support on pages with the most valuable marketing motions and focus most of our on-page optimization efforts product pages.

What we prioritize

Our goals are to develop keyword targeting that supports revenue growth, implement technical improvements, and to create a culture of SEO across our organization so everyone can contribute to search optimization.

We will focus on researching keyword targeting for content clusters, keyword groups of related terms that link to a pillar page.

We'll also improve technical SEO on all GitLab websites, starting with [about.gitlab.com](#) expanding outward to docs and our SaaS application.

As a small team, we cannot build or maintain every aspect of optimization. GitLab values everyone's contributions, so we will strive to create a culture of SEO to help everyone at GitLab contribute to our success by optimizing our website and SaaS application.

What we won't prioritize

We won't build links with large scale outreach. Our link profile is robust and healthy thanks to our product on [gitlab.com](#), and we don't need to spend our existing resources to grow links. We'll work to continue growing organic link growth with our Corporate Marketing focus on influencer strategy, but the Growth Marketing team won't spend any time on large-scale link building.

We won't use underhanded tactics to win traffic. GitLab will avoid grayhat or blackhat SEO techniques designed to trick search engines into sending us visitors. We won't hide content from visitors on page, spam keywords, or other tactics to prioritize short-term growth.

Measuring success

Keyword clusters

Our goal is to move our target keywords to the top 3 positions as often as possible. We'll need proper keyword targeting, on-page optimization, and technical optimization across our sites to achieve this goal. We will measure keyword position over time, and our measure of keyword success will focus on the visibility of our keywords by content cluster.

For example, we want to increase the visibility of our CI keywords in SEMRush, a tool for tracking our SEO progress.

Technical SEO

We want to move the site health for marketing pages on [about.gitlab.com](#) above 90%. This

excludes the handbook and jobs pages. We will measure our site health with the site audit score from SEMRush.

Creating a culture of SEO

We'll measure the success of our SEO culture by looking at the site health for the handbook and jobs pages on about.gitlab.com and the overall site health of our SaaS application.

We can use SEMRush site audit tool to measure handbook and jobs pages. We'll need to consider how to measure success in the application.

Keyword clusters

Goal

Our goal is to expand GitLab's presence in search results used by our target audiences.

We are building keyword families that mirror the focus of Marketing at GitLab. We want to identify terms related to CI, SCM, and DevSecOps to help the content team build pages to raise awareness of our product-related use cases.

Our keyword families help us create content clusters to compete for top-level terms and grow visitors through a collection of lower volume keywords. Lower volume keywords function as cluster pages, often with similar terms, and these pages link to a pillar page with our primary keyword for each family.

Pillars are set by researching the current competitive marketplace and finding common patterns in how other companies talk about specific development practices.

Once we've determined the pillars, we do keyword research to find related terms and combine those related terms with common search modifiers that identify intent.

Technical SEO improvements

Goal

Our goal is to make sure our sites are built to surface the right information to search engines.

Search engines do their best to deliver the right information to their users. To do this, they rely on sites using infrastructure and organization that meets their standards.

GitLab will give search engines relevant signals to help them understand when our product or website can help fulfill their needs. This means making it clear our URLs are authoritative, we avoid duplicate content, on-page factors match visitor intent, and all relevant resources are available to search crawlers.

We use site health tools and web analytics to understand how search engines and visitors navigate our site.

The Search Marketing team is responsible for the execution of technical SEO for marketing pages

on about.gitlab.com and help identify and coach responsible teams for SEO execution in the handbook, docs site, and product.

Creating a culture of SEO

Goal

The Search Marketing team will create a culture of SEO to grow best practices with teams across GitLab to help manage SEO for the handbook, docs site, and product.

At GitLab, we believe that everyone can contribute. This leads the Search Marketing team to focus on teaching what we know so that every aspect of GitLab's business can reach its full organic search potential.

For our initial focus, the Search Marketing team will create videos to share best practices for on-page content and long-term care of URLs, including managing internal redirects.

How our SEO strategy impacts content strategy

We want to build content clusters that match the intent of our target visitors with relevant content with a depth designed to engage people as they land on a page.

Our pages should minimize keyword overlap in page titles and headings, and avoid keyword stuffing.

No pages should have duplicate titles, descriptions, or on-page content.

The next level of GitLab organic growth

Focusing on these strategic goals will help GitLab reach a new level of recognition and authority. Achieving these goals will establish GitLab's place in the software community, and help us accelerate awareness of our solutions in the DevOps community.

SECTION: marketing/inbound-marketing/search-marketing/sitebulb.md

About

Sitebulb is a website auditing tool for search engine optimization.

Access

Access is limited based on the amount of licenses we've purchased. To request access, follow the standard access request process. Depending on the business case and availability of licenses, your request may be granted or denied.

Use

The inbound marketing team are the primary business owners and users of Sitebulb as it is used

to auditing our marketing site (about.gitlab.com).

Training

1. Getting started guide

Support

1. Support page
1. support@sitebulb.com
1. seo-improvement

SECTION: marketing/inbound-marketing/search-marketing/testing.md

We test changes at GitLab to verify a hypothesis for design or copy changes. These changes can use a variety of tools and methods, but the goal is the same: to make changes to help improve the visitor experience and better explain the value of GitLab.

We don't test fixes for typos, link updates, or other structural improvements to the site.

Goals

1. Validate and challenge our assumptions
1. Gain business insight
1. Improve customer experience

Always be testing

Testing requires a control and a variant within the same time period, while holding all other variables constant. Using A/B testing tools allow us to create tests to follow testing best practices and g